# Should You Read George Orwell's "1984" with Your Kids? (And What to Discuss)

Let's say you have an urge to reread George Orwell's *1984*. If you're around my age, you probably encountered it as assigned reading **at some point** in high school. You might be **revisiting** it for no particular reason, of course. It's just a book—an incredibly prescient, albeit depressing, one. Interestingly, it's **making its way back to** the top of Amazon's bestseller list this year (pro tip: If you have Amazon Prime, you can borrow the Kindle version for free).

If you've never read it, *1984* is often described as a journey into a "chilling, totalitarian dystopia" where "Big Brother is always watching" and "the truth exists because the Party says it's true." Despite being written in 1949, it highlights that modern politics doesn't hold a monopoly on doomsday scenarios.

You might feel inclined to read or reread *1984* and wonder if it's something you could share with your kid(s), and if so, how you should discuss it. Here's some guidance.

## Is *1984* Suitable for Children?

The short answer is no; it's not. The novel contains complex social themes, violence, and sex. Typically, it's assigned to juniors or seniors (17–18 years old) in a school setting. However, the longer answer is yes, older children can handle *1984*, especially if you read it alongside them. Personally, I think it's appropriate for any high school-aged kid (14+) with minimal concern (bearing in mind that it's a disturbing read at any age). I'd have allowed my own children to read it in middle

school, but this depends on each child's maturity. If your kid does read it then, be prepared to discuss it with them to ensure they process it healthily.

## How Should We Approach the Actual Reading?

I'm a huge fan of reading aloud (even when kids are old enough to read independently!), but I usually reserve this for books with engaging dialogue or humor, which *1984* lacks. If you spend a lot of time in the car with your teen (maybe you have a long commute?), consider the audiobook version and listen together. The simplest approach, though, would be to read independently and **set aside time** to discuss each section. Avoid making it feel too structured, as that might turn it into a chore ("Moooooooom!"). Since the book is divided into three sections and an appendix, plan to check in after each one.

## What Should We Talk About?

This is ultimately up to you, but here are some suggestions. I'm a big fan of the Socratic Method (asking questions to spark discussion), and I'm not suggesting turning this into a series of lectures. The goal is to explore what your child is getting from the book and what they think.

## Before Starting the Book:

1. *What was happening in the world in the late 1940s when the book was written?*
2. *Why do you think Orwell wrote this book?*
3. *Based on what you know, what do you think the story will be like?*

## After Reading Part 1:

1. *What do you think of Winston so far? (Consider his job, his desire to break the rules, his viewpoint.)*
2. *What Newspeak words have you encountered, and what do you think of them? What do you think they're designed to do, and do you believe it works?*
3. *Does the level of surveillance Orwell describes seem like an exaggerated fantasy, or do you find it plausible? (This is a great opportunity to discuss privacy on the Internet and personal devices.)*

## After Reading Part 2:

1. *What do you think of Julia? Does her attraction to Winston seem believable?*
2. *How do you understand the difference between the proles and Party members? What makes someone belong to one group or the other?*
3. *Did you expect Winston and Julia to be caught? Did it happen as you thought it would? What surprised you most?*

## After Reading Part 3:

1. *What was the most disturbing part of Winston's experience in the Ministry of Love?*
2. *Do you think torture can change someone's beliefs, not just force compliance? Why or why not?*
3. *What do you think Orwell's ultimate lesson was?*

I'm not offering any "right answers" here. While there are obvious themes throughout, the discussion itself is the most valuable part. Often, the most profound insights are found in nuances rather than blatant messages.

## But Wait, There's More About *1984*...

I didn't cover the appendix. Some scholars consider it the most important part, but it can be challenging for teenagers (and adults) to digest. It's **worth exploring** if you're eager for more insight into Orwell's intentions. For additional perspective, I recommend *Reading 1984 in the Age of Trump* and *Teaching 1984 in 2016*. These works offer deeper insights into Orwell's intentions and modern parallels.

Ultimately, *1984* offers a platform for teenagers to **voice their fears and anxieties** in a way that feels safe. For example, they might feel hesitant to say, "I'm worried that the government doesn't care about the truth," but discussing Winston's job altering historical records can be **a gateway to** deeper conversations about our world today.